‘Yes, sir, we do.’

‘Let us pick up Ravi Shankar.’

‘What about Shubha Sundaram?’

‘First Ravi Shankar.’

Shankar was brought to Malligai within hours. The scrutiny of photographs recovered from his possession showed Nalini, along with a few others. During his interrogation, Shankar identified one of the characters in the photographs. It was Nalini’s brother—Bhagyanathan. The name rang a bell. His name had figured in a note to Haribabu, where the former had asked to pay the electricity bill of Muthuraja and hand over the same to Murugan. And Murugan’s name had already featured in documents seized from Koneswaran.

‘Place Bhagyanathan under surveillance. Round the clock. No slip-ups,’ Verma said.

‘I am putting Chelladurai on the task right away, sir,’ came Ragothaman’s instant reply.

The ‘Q Branch’ had confirmed that Nalini was working in an adhesive-manufacturing company and drew a monthly salary of Rs 2,000. She had attended office until 6 June—a fortnight after the assassination. She had placed her resignation letter in everybody’s absence in the office premises. Unconfirmed reports suggested she had used a duplicate key and entered her office on a Sunday to do that.

Armed with information on Nalini, Anirudhya dropped into the office of Anabante Silicon Pvt. Ltd in Adyar. It was about to close for the day. Just one person, Sujaya Narayan, spoke to Anirudhya. She said, ‘Nalini was working here as a private secretary to the managing director. The girl took half a day’s leave on 21 May, saying she wanted to go to Kanchipuram and purchase a sari. She left around noon.’ A tailor close to her office said he had seen her attending office since the day of the assassination. ‘Everybody was shocked to see her picture in the newspaper in connection with the assassination,’ said the tailor. He lived on top of his shop. He claimed to have seen a woman getting out of an autorickshaw in front of the office around five in the morning on Sunday. But he was not sure if it was Nalini